



HOW TO REALLY THINK IN ENGLISH

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About the Author



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He has helped over 40,000 students prepare for their IELTS Speaking test with his online courses.

Can you really think in English?

Sure you can, but you need to use the right techniques.

In this PDF I will show you

- How to fix your translating habit
- The different ways that we think
- How YOU can finally think in English

Also, I will show you some techniques to help you build your “English-thinking” habit



PART 1

Fix your Translating Habit

How to Fix your Translating Habit

Translating is not always bad.

In fact, sometimes it is necessary and can be useful.

However, the problem is when we translate all the time, and translate word by word.

Then we will make many more mistakes when speaking.

So here I will show you **5 simple ways** to help you stop translating.



1. Learn and Practice Chunks

When you **learn** new vocabulary and start to **practice** it, make sure you not only learn individual words, but also learn short phrases with the word.

These short phrases are often called '**chunks**'



For example, let's take the word for this image; this is **a tram**.

So, using a dictionary, you can also learn some chunks:

- **A tram**
- **To take the tram**
- **To get on the tram**
- **To go by tram**

You can say these chunks out loud or just ‘think’ them.

Then you can make up and think of some simple phrases.

Think of things that are true for you.

- **I never take the tram**
- **I don’t want to get on the tram**
- **I could go by tram**
- **I prefer not to take the tram**

Do this ‘thinking activity’ each time you learn new words and chunks.

2. Notice and Learn Adjacent Pairs

Conversations with 2 speakers are full of two-part exchanges.

When the second phrase is dependent on the first, we call this an **adjacent pair**.

Adjacent (adj.) = together, side by side.

English conversations are full of adjacent pairs.

For example, you can see them in **greetings**:

Tom: Hello

Jane: Hello

Tom: How are you?

Jane: Not too bad

Here are 3 more examples:

Thanking:

Tom: Thank you

Jane: Your welcome

Tom: Thanks

Jane: No problem

Tom: Thank you so much

Jane: That's quite alright

Adjacent Pairs tend...

- to be fixed
- to have a limited number
- to be the most common natural response

Here are some more examples

Invitations:

Tom: Do you want to come to my party?

Jane: I'd love to

Tom: Do you want to come for dinner?

Jane: That'd be great

Asking for information:

Tom: Has Mary arrived yet?

Jane: I don't think so

Tom: Did you watch the football last night?

Jane: Yeah, it was great, wasn't it?

Giving Orders:

Tom: This needs doing right now

Jane: OK, I'll get on to it

These are useful, but as your level gets higher, you need to also be able to be flexible and learn to offer alternatives.

Giving Orders

Here are 3 alternative responses for the example above

Tom: This needs doing right now

Jane: I'll sort it out

Jane: Don't worry, I'll make sure it's done

Jane: No worries, we'll do it

So, when involved in conversations or when watching films or series, try to look out for and notice adjacent pairs.

Practice them by thinking them!

3. Learn and Use Collocations

Collocations are 2 or 3 words that often go together.

For example, they can be **an adjective + a noun**

Black tea

Green tea

Tea leaves

Tea bag(s)

Collocations are often **verbs + nouns**

- **To drink tea**
- **To sip tea**
- **To have some tea**
- **To slurp your tea**

So when you learn vocabulary, **learn collocations**.

This will help you focus on phrases, not just individual words.

And this will help stop you translating.

When you practice thinking in English, you can make up and think your own short phrases with these collocations.

For example,

I feel like a cup of tea

I love black tea!

Shall I have tea leaves or tea bags today?

Do this ‘thinking activity’ each time you learn new collocations.

4. Use a Mono-lingual Dictionary

Using an English-to-English dictionary will help you think in English and avoid translation.

This is especially true, if you also make notes in English.

A good online dictionary that I often use is this one:

[Merriam-Webster Dictionary](#)

5. Keep Notes in English

When taking notes in class, or from your own study, try to keep 90% of your notes in English.

This takes more time at first and you will be tempted to just write the translation.

Avoid the temptation.

Take the time to use a mono-lingual dictionary and keep most of your notes in English.

It will become easier and faster for you, and the benefits are huge.

This was one of the most important changes I made when learning Spanish.

It made a huge difference.

I was soon thinking like a Spanish person.



PART 2

How We Think

How We Think

There are 2 main ways that we think.

1. Idle thinking

This is the voice in our head that seems to be talking all the time.

The thoughts are often unconnected, illogical and sometimes annoying.

Basically, it is thinking everything that 'goes through our head'.

It is sometimes hard to control.

2. Reflective thinking

This is active thinking where we make an effort to think about plans and actions.

Many people have 'thinking' time in their day, to think about work, family or holiday plans.

This is reflective thinking.

It is usually easier to control.

Thinking Activities

When we think in our mother tongue, we do a variety of activities.

So, when you are doing these **thinking activities**, you can start trying to do them in English.

It is not as difficult as it sounds, when you know what activity you are doing.

Here are **5 common activities** we do when thinking.

You can use the English phrases I give below as examples to help you think in English.

Just remember, whether you think or speak, the language is the same.

Thinking in English is really just talking to yourself in English!

1. Have Opinions

When native-speakers think in English, we don't usually think things like

That is a tree
That is a book

However, I admit, this can be useful for beginner students.

You can see something and 'think' of the name.

However, English speakers more commonly **have opinions** about things we see.

For example, I see a car and think

- **What an awful car**
- **I hate that colour**
- **What kind of car is that?**
- **I should know that**
- **My brother would know**
- **He knows everything about cars...**

So when you see things, start to think your opinion in your head!

2. Tell Yourself What to Do

Another common thinking activity is telling ourselves what to do.

We talk to ourselves, like a dialogue.

We tell ourselves to do things, often using imperatives, such as these examples, when you wake up.

- **Come on!**
- **Get up!**
- **It's late**
- **I need to get up**
- **It's too cold**
- **I can do this**
- **Maybe not**
- **Just 2 more minutes in bed**

And then you fall back to sleep, but you are thinking in English.

Have a go!

Try this any time when you are telling yourself to do things.

3. Have Ideas

The next common thinking activity is having ideas.

Imagine, you are quietly drinking your morning coffee and then suddenly you have an idea.

Try thinking your ideas in English!

I recently had the following ‘chain of thought’

- **I think I’ll go to the shopping mall**
- **That’ll be nice, I can get a coffee and lunch too**
- **I’d love to go to New York!**
- **Why don’t I book a flight?**
- **No, I can’t afford it**
- **Maybe next year!**

In this case, when thinking your ideas, you can think phrases like the following,

I think I’ll _____

I’d love to _____

Why don’t I _____?

4. Identify Problems and Find Solutions

Next, as well as ideas, we often think about problems and solutions.

This can start off as a reflective activity, but sometimes ends up as ‘Idle Thinking’.

We cannot stop thinking about the problem and the horrible ‘what if this happens!’

So, start thinking about your problems in English.

You might find these phrases useful to ‘think’

Problems :

What can I do about this?

What has happened?

No, that won't work!

That's no good!

Why does she always do that?

Don't forget to think about solutions in English too.

You can use phrase like these,

Solutions:

What I need to do is _____

I'm going to _____

I could _____

I should _____

Ok I will do this!

5. Plans, Decisions and Regrets

Finally, another common reflective thinking activity is **making plans**.

After making a plan you will sometimes **take a decision**

Unfortunately, at times, you may **regret** it.

Try making your plans by thinking in English.

Here are some templates to help you.

Plans and decisions:

I'm going to _____

I'll _____

Why not try that?

I might try this

Ok, sure ? Yes, let's do it

If you have regrets, here are some templates to help you think about those too!

Regrets:

I should've done that

Why did I do that?

What was I thinking?

I shouldn't've done that



PART 3

**Build your 'English
Thinking' Habit**

So to think in English, you need to think like you think in your native tongue.

To be honest, it is just a skill.

It is a skill you need to practice every day.

TIP 1

Start just 1 minute a day!

It's a good idea to break your learning goals into small units.

Start small then build up.

So just have a goal of thinking in English for 1 minute each day.

Then after some days, you can increase to 2 minutes or more.

Do what feels comfortable and possible to achieve.

TIP 2

Practice at the same time, same place, everyday

A popular idea is that it takes 21 days to make an activity into a habit.

In fact, deeper research suggests it is more like 67 days.

The important thing is to practice your thinking in English, day after day.

Keep going.

And to make it easy to keep going, make it fun and simple to do.

Then you will make it a habit.

TIP 3

If you don't know a word in English, use your mother-tongue

A common problem that stops many people thinking in English, is that they lack vocabulary.

Or they think of something, but don't know the word in English.

That's fine.

Just think in English, and for the word you don't know in English, think in your mother-tongue.

Then later, go and look up that word in a dictionary.

Remember, your thinking time is about building that habit in a simple way.

It is not about building vocabulary or using complex grammar.

Keep it simple and make it a habit.

TIP 4

Create 'English Moments'

The more you listen to English, the easier it is to think in English.

I know it is hard to 'surround' yourself in an English environment, but you can create 'English moments'.

10 minutes reading a blog article,

20 minutes listening to a podcast episode,

40 minutes watching an episode of a series on Netflix.

All of this will help you notice the language of conversations, like the adjacent pairs above, and also help you think more in English

TIP 5

Use a prop

A prop is an item that actors carry or wear to help them ‘get in to character’.

Thinking in English, is a step towards building your own identity as an English speaker.

Your goal is not just to be an English student to become a confident English speaker.

This means you take on the identity or even character of an English speaker.

I don’t mean become English.

You are still **you**, you still have your own nationality, culture and language, but you also have your own ‘English identity’.

For some people, it is almost like wearing a mask, or becoming a slightly different person when you speak and think in English.

Choosing a prop to carry or wear when you practice thinking in English can help you.

It might be a hat, a scarf, a pen, a cup of tea, anything to help feel more like an English speaker, or in this case, an English thinker!

Enjoy thinking in English and practice everyday!

If you liked this PDF, you can find more information to help you learn English here:

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